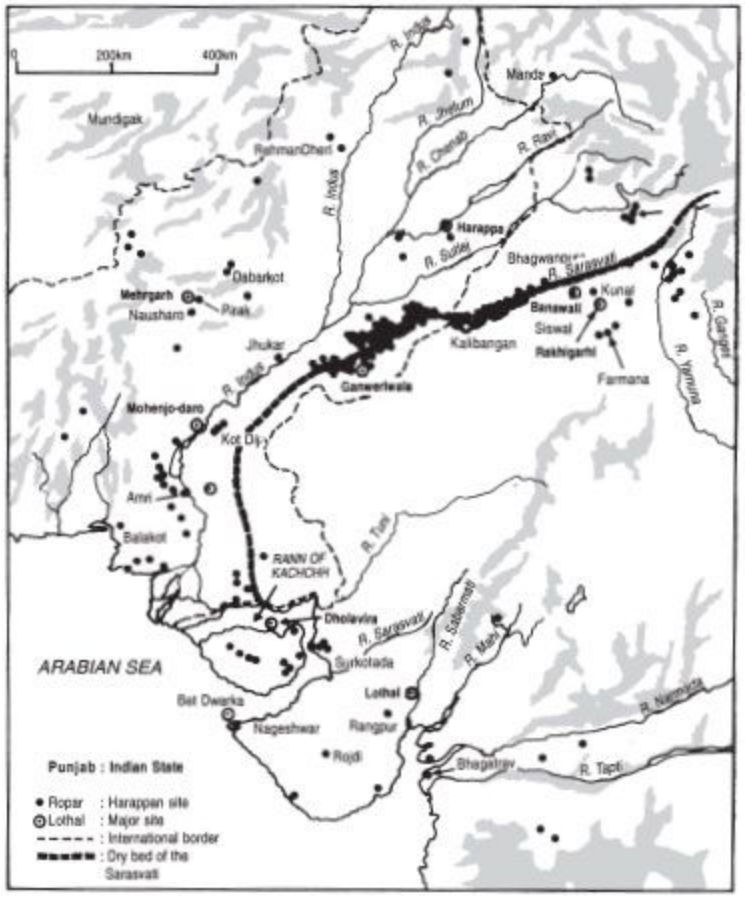


Dry Bed of the Saraswati River
(source: *The Lost River: On the Trail of the Sarasvati* by Michel Danino)

What does the drying of the Ghaggar tell us about the fate of the Harappans? It appears that the climate was wetter and the Ghaggar was in full flow during the early phase of the civilization. Perhaps the earthquakes of 2600 BC, attested both at Kalibangan and Dholavira, were related to the tectonic shifts that affected either the Yamuna or the Sutlej. Interestingly, we find that the mature Harappan phase takes off only after the Ghaggar was already drying. One wonders if the drying weather and the dying river created a climatic sweet-spot that allowed the urban centres to flourish. This may explain why there is a dense concentration of mature Harappan sites in the Thar desert, around the time we think that the Ghaggar may have already started to dry. Unfortunately, around 2000 BC, conditions again took a sharp turn for the worse.